

# Groups

**Definition 1.1:** Let  $G$  be a non-empty set, equipped with a binary operation, that is, a "multiplication" map

$$\cdot : G \times G \longrightarrow G$$

Our notations will be

$$\cdot (g, h) =: g \bullet h$$

or simply  $gh$  if the name of the operation can be understood.

**Definition 1.2:** A set  $G$ , endowed with a binary operation  $(\cdot)$  ( $ie(G, \cdot)$ ), is a group if:

i) the operation is associative, that is

$$(\forall g, h, k \in G) \quad (g \cdot h) \cdot k = g \cdot (h \cdot k);$$

ii) there exists an identity element  $e_G$  for  $G$ , that is

$$(\exists e_G \in G)(\forall g \in G) : g \cdot e_G = g = e_G \cdot g;$$

iii) every element in  $G$  has an inverse with respect to  $\cdot$ , that is,

$$(\forall g \in G)(\exists h \in G) : g \cdot h = e_G = h \cdot g.$$

**Example 1.3** The trivial group  $G = \{e\}$ .

**Example 1.4** The following are groups under ordinary addition:  $(\mathbb{Z}, +)$ ,  $(\mathbb{Q}, +)$ ,  $(\mathbb{R}, +)$ ,  $(\mathbb{C}, +)$ . The subset  $\{+1, -1\}$  of  $\mathbb{Z}$  is a group under multiplication.

Note that the above examples are commutative

**Example 1.5** Consider the set of all  $n \times n$  matrices with real entries. Under ordinary matrix multiplication, these form a group. This is an example of a non-commutative group. This is denoted by  $GL_n(\mathbb{R})$

## Commutative groups

Given a group  $(G, \cdot)$  such that  $(\forall g, h \in G) \quad g \cdot h = h \cdot g$ , we say that the operation is commutative. We say that two elements  $g, h$  "commute" if  $gh = hg$ . In a commutative group, any two elements commute. Such groups are said to be abelian groups.

The notation used in treating abelian groups differs from that used for standard groups. The operation in an abelian group  $A$  is, as a rule, denoted by  $+$  and is called addition. The identity is called  $0_A$  and the inverse of an element  $a \in A$  is denoted by  $-a$ .

Now in a standard group setting, the conventional power notation can be used  $g^0 = e_G$  and for a positive integer  $n$ :

$$g^n = g \cdots g \quad (n\text{-times})$$

$$g^{-n} = g^{-1} \cdots g^{-1} \quad (n\text{-times})$$

On the other hand, in the abelian group setting the power notation is replaced by 'multiple'  $0a = 0$  and for a positive integer  $n$ :

$$na = a + a + \cdots + a \quad (n\text{-times})$$

$$(-n)a = (-a) + \cdots + (-a) \quad (n\text{-times})$$

## Order

**Definition 1.6:** An element  $g$  of a group  $G$  has finite order if  $g^n = e$  for some positive integer  $n$ . In this case, the order  $|g|$  is the smallest positive  $n$  such that  $g^n = e$ . If  $g$  does not have finite order, then  $|g| = \infty$ . By definition, if  $g^n = e$  for some positive integer  $n$ , then  $|g| \leq n$ .

**Lemma 1.7:** If  $g^n = e$  for some integer  $n$ , then  $|g|$  is a divisor of  $n$ .

**Proof:** By definition of order,  $n \geq |g|$ , that is  $n - |g| \geq 0$ . Thus by the division algorithm  $\exists 0 \leq r < |g|, m \in \mathbb{Z}$  such that  $n = |g| \cdot m + r$ . So that  $r = n - |g| \cdot m \geq 0$ . Note that

$$g^r = g^{n-|g|\cdot m} = g^n \cdot (g^{|g|})^{-m} = e \cdot e^{-m} = e$$

By definition of order,  $|g|$  is the smallest positive integer such that  $g^{|g|} = e$ . Since  $r$  is smaller than  $|g|$  and  $g^r = e$ ,  $r$  cannot be positive, hence  $r = 0$  necessarily. So that  $0 = n - |g| \cdot m$ . Thus we have  $n = |g| \cdot m$ , proving that  $n$  is indeed an integer multiple of  $|g|$  as claimed.

**Corollary 1.8:** Let  $g$  be an element of finite order, and let  $N \in \mathbb{Z}$ . Then  $g^N = e \iff N$  is a multiple of  $|g|$ .

**Definition 1.9:** If  $G$  is finite as a set, its order  $|G|$  is the number of its elements; we write  $|G| = \infty$  if  $G$  is infinite. note that  $|g| \leq |G| \forall g \in G$ . Indeed, this is a vacuosly true if  $|G| = \infty$ , if  $G$  is finite, cosider the  $|G| + 1$  powers

$$g^0 = e, g, g^2, g^3, \dots, g^{|G|}$$

of  $g$ . These cannot all be distinct, hence  $(\exists i, j) 0 \leq i < j \leq |G|$  such that  $g^i = g^j$   
By Cancellations(That is multiplying on the right by  $g^{-i}$ )

$$g^{j-i} = e,$$

Showing  $|g| \leq (j - i) \leq |G|$

**Proposition 1.10:** Let  $g \in G$  be an element of finite order. Then  $g^m$  has finite order  $\forall m \geq 0$  and

$$|g^m| = \frac{\text{lcm}(m, |g|)}{m} = \frac{|g|}{\text{gcd}(m, |g|)}$$

**Proof:** The equality of the tow numbers  $\frac{\text{lcm}(m, |g|)}{m}$  and  $\frac{|g|}{\text{gcd}(m, |g|)}$  follows from the elementary properties of gcd and lcm:

$$\text{lcm}(a, b) = \frac{ab}{\text{gcd}(a, b)} \forall a \text{ and } b$$

We need only to prove that  $|g^m| = \frac{lcm(m, |g|)}{m}$ . The order of  $g^m$  is the least positive integer  $d$  such that  $g^{md} = e$ , that is  $md$  is a multiple of  $|g|$  (by corollary 1.8). In other words  $m|g^m|$  is the smallest multiple of  $m$  which is also a multiple of  $|g|$ :  $m|g^m| = lcm(m, |g|)$ . Thus

$$\frac{lcm(m, |g|)}{m} = |g^m|$$

The rest of the results follows immediately. In general for commuting elements,

**Proposition 1.11:** If  $gh = hg$ , then  $|gh|$  divides  $lcm(|g|, |h|)$ . **Proof:** let  $|g| = m, |h| = n$ . If  $N$  is any common multiple of  $m$  and  $n$ , then  $g^N = h^N = e$  by Corollary 1.8. Since  $g$  and  $h$  commute

$$(gh)^N = \underbrace{(gh)(gh)\dots(gh)}_{n \text{ times}} = \underbrace{gg\dots g}_{n \text{ times}} \cdot \underbrace{hh\dots h}_{n \text{ times}} = g^N \cdot h^N = e$$

Since this holds for every common multiple of  $N$  of  $m$  and  $n$ , in particular it holds for  $lcm(m, n)$ , so

$$(gh)^{lcm(m, n)} = e$$

The statement follows from Lemma 1.7

### Exercises

1. Consider the following sets

- $\emptyset$  : the empty set
- $\mathbb{N}$  : the set of natural numbers (that is non-negative integers)
- $\mathbb{Z}$  : the set of integers
- $\mathbb{Q}$  : the set of rational numbers
- $\mathbb{R}$  : the set of real numbers
- $\mathbb{C}$  : the set of complex numbers

Decide which of these are made into groups by conventional operations such as  $+$  and  $\cdot$ .

2. Prove that  $(gh)^{-1} = h^{-1}g^{-1} \forall$  elements  $g, h$  of a group  $G$
3. Suppose that  $g^2 = e$  for all elements  $g$  of a group  $G$ , prove that  $G$  is commutative
4. Prove that there is only one possible multiplication table for  $G$  if  $G$  has exactly 1, 2 or 3 elements. Analyze the possible multiplication tables for groups with exactly 4 elements of  $G$ . Use these tables to prove that all groups with  $\leq 4$  elements are commutative
5. Prove Corollary 1.8 in the notes
6. Let  $G$  be a finite abelian group with exactly one element of order 2. Prove that  $\prod_{g \in G} g = f$

7. Let  $G$  be a finite group of order  $n$  and let  $m$  be the number of elements  $g \in G$  of order exactly 2. Prove that  $n - m$  is odd. Deduce that if  $n$  is even, then  $G$  necessarily contains elements of order 2.
8. Suppose the order of  $g$  is odd. What can you say about the order of  $g^2$

## Symmetric Groups

**Definition 1.12:** A permutation of a set  $A$  is a bijective map  $A \rightarrow A$ .

**Definition 1.13:** Let  $A$  be a set. The symmetric group or group of permutations of  $A$ , denoted  $S_A$ , is the group of all bijective maps from  $A$  to itself under composition.

The group of permutations of the set  $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$  is denoted by  $S_n$ . The terminology is easily justified, the bijections from  $A$  to itself amounts to permuting the elements of  $A$ . This operation may be viewed as a transformation of  $A$  which does not change it (as a set) hence a "symmetry" i.e. groups  $S_A$  are very large. For example if  $A = \{1, \dots, n\}$  then  $|S_n| = n!$  To get a feel for what these are we consider these examples  $S_1$  is a trivial group,  $S_2$  consists of the two possible permutations

$$\begin{cases} 1 \mapsto 1 \\ 2 \mapsto 2 \end{cases} \quad \text{and} \quad \begin{cases} 1 \mapsto 2 \\ 2 \mapsto 1 \end{cases}$$

Which one can call  $e$  (identity) and  $f$  (flip) with operation

$$ee = ff = e, ef = fe = f$$

**Notation:** We will indicate an element  $\sigma \in S_n$  by listing the effect of applying  $\sigma$  underneath the list  $1, \dots, n$  as a matrix. Thus the elements  $e, f$  in  $S_2$  may be denoted by:

$$e = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \quad f = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$$

Using the same notation,  $S_3$  consists of

$$\left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \right\}$$

The following describes how any two permutations are multiplied. For example:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$$

We obtain the answer by observing the following:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \text{ sends } 1 \text{ to } 3 \text{ and } \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \text{ sends } 3 \text{ to } 3. \text{ So } \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \text{ sends } 1 \text{ to } 3$$

Continuing in this fashion we obtain the desired results.

## Dihedral groups

A symmetry is a transformation which preserves a structure. The symmetries will naturally form groups. One context in which this notion may be visualised clearly is that of 'geometric figures' such as polygons in the plane.

The dihedral groups may be defined as these groups of symmetries for the regular polygons. Placing the polygon so that it is centered at the origin (thereby excluding translations as possible symmetries), we see that the dihedral group for a regular  $n$ -sided polygon consists of the  $n$  rotations by  $2\pi/n$  radians about the origin, and  $n$  distinct reflections about lines through the origin and a vertex or a midpoint of a side. Thus the dihedral group for a regular  $n$ -sided polygon consists of  $2n$  elements. We will denote this group by  $D_{2n}$ . We will denote this group by  $D_{2n}$ . There is a way to relate dihedral groups to symmetric groups by considering the fact that a symmetry of a regular polygon is determined by what happens to its vertices. For instance, Label the vertices of an equilateral triangle by 1, 2, 3. Then a counterclockwise rotation by an angle of  $2\pi/3$  sends 1 to 3, 3 to 2, and 2 to 1 and no other symmetry of the triangle does the same. In other words with the counterclockwise rotation of the equivalent triangle by  $2\pi/3$  we associate to it the permutation.

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \in S_3$$

Such a labeling defines a function  $D_6 \rightarrow S_3$  which is a group homomorphism, and in addition this function is injective. We can think of this as a faithful action of  $D_6$  on the set  $\{1, 2, 3\}$ . These function induced by the labelings are group homomorphisms.

## Cyclic groups and Modular arithmetic

Let  $n$  be a positive integer. Consider the equivalence relation on  $\mathbb{Z}$  defined by  $(\forall a, b \in \mathbb{Z})$ :

$$a \equiv b \pmod{n} \iff n|(b - a)$$

This is called congruence modulo  $n$ . The set of equivalence classes is often denoted by  $\mathbb{Z}_{\times n}$ ,  $\mathbb{Z}/(n)$ , or  $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$  or  $\mathbb{F}_{\times}$ . We will use the  $\mathbb{Z}_{\times}$ . So when we write  $[a]_n$  we mean the equivalence class of the integer  $a$  modulo  $n$ , or simply  $[a]$  if no ambiguity arises. The set  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  consists exactly  $n$  elements, namely

$$[0]_n, [1]_n, \dots, [n-1]_n$$

We can use the group structure on  $\mathbb{Z}$  to include an (abelian) group structure on  $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ . In order to do this, we define an operation  $+$  on  $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$  setting  $\forall a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$

$$[a] + [b] := [a + b]$$

In the following lemma we show that the operation is well defined: It shows that the result of the operation does not depend on choice of the representations of

the classes. **Lemma 1.13:** If  $a \equiv a' \pmod{n}$  and  $b \equiv b' \pmod{n}$ , then

$$a + b \equiv a' + b' \pmod{n}$$

**Proof:** By hypothesis  $n|(a' - a)$  and  $n|(b' - b)$ ; therefore  $\exists k, l \in \mathbb{Z}$  such that

$$(a' - a) = kn, \quad (b' - b) = ln$$

Then

$$(a' + b') - (a + b) = (a' - a) + (b' - b) = kn + ln = (k + l)n$$

Proving that  $n$  divides  $(a' + b') - (a + b)$  as needed.

Thus we have a binary operation  $+$  on  $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ . Next we check that the resulting structure is a group. Associativity is inherited from  $\mathbb{Z}$ .

$$([a] + [b]) + [c] = [a + b] + [c] = [(a + b) + c] = [a + (b + c)] = [a] + ([b] + [c])$$

Similarly, the identity is  $[0]_n$  and the inverse is  $-[a]_n = [-a]_n$  are inherited from  $\mathbb{Z}$ . It is immediately checked that the resulting groups  $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$  are commutative. as the abelian group notation suggests

$$[a] + [b] = [a + b] = [b + a] = [b] + [a]$$

The abelian groups thus obtained together with  $\mathbb{Z}$ , are called cyclic groups, an alternative notation for the group  $(\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}, +)$  is  $C_n$ . This is adopted especially when one wants to use the multiplicative rather than the additive notation; so that we can say that  $C_n$  is generated by an element  $x$  with the relation  $x^n = e$ . Note the fact that the element  $[1]_n \in \mathbb{Z}_n$  generates the group in the sense that every other element may be obtained as a multiple of this element. For example, if  $m \geq 0$  is an integer, then

$$[m]_n = \underbrace{[1 + \dots + 1]_n}_{m \text{ times}} = \underbrace{[1]_n + \dots + [1]_n}_{m \text{ times}} = m \cdot [1]_n$$

by saying that  $[1]_m$  generates  $\mathbb{Z}_n$ , it implies that the order of  $[1]_n \in \mathbb{Z}_n$  is  $n$ : that also means that  $n$  multiples  $0 \cdot [1]_n, 1 \cdot [1]_n, \dots, (n-1) \cdot [1]_n$  must all be distinct and hence they must fill up  $\mathbb{Z}_n$

**Proposition 1.14:** The order of  $[m]_n$  in  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  is 1 if  $n|m$ , and more generally

$$|[m]_n| = \frac{n}{\gcd(m, n)}$$

**Proof:** if  $n = m$ , then  $[m]_n = [0]_n$ . If  $n$  does not divide  $m$ , observe again that  $[m]_n = m \cdot [1]_n$ . Now the order of  $[m]_n$  is the least positive integer  $d$  of which  $d \cdot [m]_n = [0]_n = dm[1]_n$ . Thus we see that  $d \cdot m$  is the least multiple of  $m$  and which is also a multiple of  $n$  as  $n$  divides  $dm$ . So by Proposition 1.10

$$d \cdot m = |[m]_n| m = \text{lcm}(m, n). \text{ So that } |[m]_n| = \frac{\text{lcm}(m, n)}{m} = \frac{n}{\gcd(m, n)}$$

as required. **Remarks:** As a consequence of the above, the order of every element of  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  divides  $n = |\mathbb{Z}_n|$ , the order of the group. This is a general feature of the order of elements in a finite group.

**Corollary 1.16:** The class  $[m]_n$  generates  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  if and only if  $\gcd(m, n) = 1$ . A consequence of the above result is that if  $n = p$  is a prime integer, then every non-zero class in the group  $\mathbb{Z}_p$  generates it.

Note that there is a well-defined multiplication on  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  given by  $[a]_n \cdot [b]_n = [ab]_n$ . However, this operation does not define a group structure on  $\mathbb{Z}_n$ ; indeed, the class  $[0]_n$  does not have a multiplicative inverse. However, for any positive integer  $n$ , denote by  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  the subset of  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  consisting of classes  $[m]_n$  such that  $\gcd(m, n) = 1$ :

$$(\mathbb{Z}_n)^* := \{[m]_n \in \mathbb{Z}_n \mid \gcd(m, n) = 1\}$$

This subset is well-defined: if  $m \equiv m' \pmod{n}$  then  $\gcd(m, n) = 1 \iff \gcd(m', n) = 1$ . So the defining property of classes in  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  is independence of representations

**Proposition 1.17:** Multiplication makes  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  into a group. **Proof:** Properties of  $\gcd$ 's show that if  $\gcd(m_1, n) = \gcd(m_2, n)$ , then  $\gcd(m_1 m_2, n) = 1$ . Therefore the product of two elements in  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  is an element of  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  and defines a binary operation

$$(\mathbb{Z}_n)^* \times (\mathbb{Z}_n)^* \mapsto (\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$$

It is clear that this operation is associative (because multiplication is associative in  $\mathbb{Z}$ );  $[1]_n$  is an element of  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  and is an identity with respect to multiplication, so all we have to check is that elements of  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  have multiplicative inverses in  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$ . This follows from Corollary 1.16. If  $\gcd(m, n) = 1$ , then  $[m]_n$  generates the additive group  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  and hence some multiples of  $[m]_n$  must equal  $[1]_n$ :  $(\exists a \in \mathbb{Z}) : a \cdot [m]_n = [1]_n$ ; this implies  $[a]_n [m]_n = [1]_n$ . Therefore  $[m]_n$  does have a multiplicative inverse in  $(\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  namely  $[a]_n$  [Check that  $[a]_n \in (\mathbb{Z}_n)^*$  i.e.  $\gcd(a, n) = 1$ ]. This completes the proof.

## Group Homomorphisms

Let  $(G, m_G)$  and  $(H, m_H)$  be two groups where.

$$m_G : G \times G \mapsto G \quad \text{and} \quad m_H : H \times H \mapsto H$$

**Definition 2.1:** A map  $\varphi : G \mapsto H$  is a group homomorphism if  $\forall a, b \in G$ ,

$$\varphi(a \cdot b) = \varphi(a) \cdot \varphi(b)$$

In other words,  $\varphi$  is a homomorphism if it 'preserves the structure'.

**Proposition 2.2:** Let  $\varphi : G \rightarrow H$  be a group homomorphism. Then

1.  $\varphi(e_G) = e_H$
2.  $\forall g \in G, \varphi(g^{-1}) = \varphi(g)^{-1}$

**Proof:**

1. To prove the first item, we make use of the cancellation property and the definition of homomorphism. Since  $e_H = e_H \cdot e_H$ ,

$$e_H \cdot \varphi(e_G) = \varphi(e_G) = \varphi(e_G \cdot e_G) = \varphi(e_G) \cdot \varphi(e_G)$$

which implies  $e_H = \varphi(e_G)$  by cancelling  $\varphi(e_G)$ .

2.  $\varphi(g^{-1}) \cdot \varphi(g) = \varphi(g^{-1} \cdot g) = \varphi(e_G) = e_H = \varphi(g)^{-1} \cdot \varphi(g)$  Thus  $\varphi(g^{-1}) = \varphi(g)^{-1}$  by cancellation.

## Examples of group homomorphisms

1. Given any two groups  $G, H$ , we can define a homomorphism  $G \rightarrow H$  by sending every element of  $G$  to the identity  $e_H$  of  $H$ . We call this map the trivial morphism.
2. The exponential function is a homomorphism from  $(\mathbb{R}, +)$  to the group  $(\mathbb{R}^+, \cdot)$  of positive real numbers, with ordinary multiplication as operation. Indeed,  $e^{a+b} = e^a e^b$ .

Another important example can be obtained as follows: let  $G$  be any group and  $g \in G$ , any element of  $G$ ; define an exponential map

$$\epsilon_g : \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow G \quad \text{by} \quad (\forall a \in \mathbb{Z}) : \epsilon_g(a) := g^a$$

Then  $\epsilon_g$  is clearly a group homomorphism. The element  $g$  generates  $G$  if and only if  $\epsilon_g$  is surjective.

The following example is an instance of the above example of group homomorphism (This works with abelian groups) Consider the quotient function

$$\prod_n : \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow [Z]_n, \quad a \mapsto a \cdot [1]_n = [a]_n :$$

. Using the notation in example (3), this function is surjective hence  $[1]_n$  generates  $\mathbb{Z}_n$ . In fact,  $[m]_n$  generates  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  if and only if  $\gcd(m, n) = 1$

**Homomorphism and order** Group homomorphisms are set functions preserving the group structure; as such, they must preserve many features of the them. As we saw in Proposition 2.2, group homomorphisms must preserve identities and inverses. It is also clear that if  $\varphi : G \rightarrow H$  is a group homomorphism and  $g$  is an element of finite order in  $G$ , then  $\varphi(g)$  must be an element of finite order in  $H$ . Indeed, if  $g^n = e_G$  for some  $n > 0$ , then

$$\varphi(g)^n = \varphi(g^n) = \varphi(e_G) = e_H$$

We make this observation more precise

**Proposition 2.3:** Let  $\varphi : G \rightarrow H$  be a group homomorphism, and let  $g \in G$  be an element of finite order. Then  $|\varphi(g)|$  divides  $|g|$ . **Proof:** We observed that  $\varphi(g)^{|g|} = e_H$ . Therefore applying lemma 1.7 gives the statement.

**Example 2.41**



1. There are no non-trivial homomorphisms  $\mathbb{Z}_n \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ . Indeed, the image of every element of  $\mathbb{Z}$  must have finite order, and the only element with finite order in  $(\mathbb{Z}, +)$  is 0.
2. There are no non-trivial homomorphism  $\varphi : C_4 \rightarrow C_7$ . Indeed, the orders of elements on  $C_4$  divide 4 and the orders of elements in  $C_7$  divide 7. Thus, the order of each  $\varphi(g)$  must divide both 4 and 7; this forces  $|\varphi(g)| = 1$  for all  $g$ , that is  $\varphi(g) = e$  for all  $g \in C_4$ .

In general under homomorphism order is not preserved. Order is preserved under isomorphisms. So what is an isomorphism?

## Isomorphisms

**Definition** An isomorphism of groups  $\varphi : G \rightarrow H$  is a group homomorphism admitting an inverse  $\varphi^{-1} : H \rightarrow G$  which is also a group homomorphism. In other words, an isomorphism of two groups  $\varphi : G \rightarrow H$  is a bijective group homomorphism.

**Proposition 2.5:** Let  $\varphi : G \rightarrow H$  be a group homomorphism. Then  $\varphi$  is an isomorphism of groups if and only if it is a bijection. **Proof:** ( $\implies$ ) is clear from the definition. For the other implication now assume  $\varphi : G \rightarrow H$  is a bijective group homomorphism. As a bijection it has an inverse  $\varphi^{-1} : H \rightarrow G$ ; we only have to check that  $\varphi^{-1}$  is a group homomorphism. Let  $h_1, h_2$  be elements of  $H$  and let  $g_1 = \varphi^{-1}(h_1)$  be the corresponding elements of  $G$ . Then

$$\varphi^{-1}(h_1 \cdot h_2) = \varphi^{-1}(\varphi(g_1)\varphi(g_2)) = \varphi^{-1}(\varphi(g_1g_2)) = g_1 \cdot g_2 = \varphi^{-1}(h_1)\varphi^{-1}(h_2)$$

as required

**Example 2.6** The function  $D_6 \rightarrow S_3$  defined previously is an isomorphism of groups, since it is a bijective group homomorphism. **Example 2.7** The exponential function  $(\mathbb{R}, +) \rightarrow (\mathbb{R}^+, \cdot)$  mentioned under the examples of homomorphisms is also an isomorphism. Note that if the exponential function  $\epsilon_g : \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow G$  determined by an element  $g \in G$  is an isomorphism, we say that  $G$  is an infinite cyclic group.

**Definition 2.8** Two groups  $G, H$  are isomorphic if there is a bijective group homomorphism  $G \rightarrow H$ . Note that "isomorphic" is an equivalence relation, we write  $G \cong H$  if  $G$  and  $H$  are isomorphic. Automorphisms of a group  $G$  are isomorphisms  $G \rightarrow G$ ; these form a group called  $\text{Aut}(G)$ .

**Definition 2.9:** A group  $G$  is cyclic if it is isomorphic to  $\mathbb{Z}$  or to  $\mathbb{C}_n = \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$  for some  $n$ .

**Proposition 2.10** Let  $\varphi : G \rightarrow H$  be an isomorphism

- $(\forall g \in G) : |\varphi(g)| = |g|$
- $G$  is commutative if and only if  $H$  is commutative

**Proof:** The first assertion follows from Proposition 2.3: the order  $\varphi(g)$  divides the order of  $g$  and on the other hand the order of  $g = \varphi^{-1}(\varphi(g))$  must

divide the order of  $\varphi(g)$ ; thus the two orders must be equal. The second assertion is an exercise. **Example 2.11**  $C_6 \cong S_3$ , since one is commutative and the other is not. Another reason is the following: in  $C_6$  there is one element of order 1, two of order 2 and two of order 3; in  $S_3$  the situation is different: one element of order 1, three elements of order 2, two elements of order 3

## Subgroups

**Definition 3.1:** Let  $(G, \cdot)$  be a group. A subgroup  $(H, \cdot)$  of  $G$  is a non-empty subset  $H$  which is also a group under the binary operation of  $G$ .

**Proposition 3.2:** A non-empty subset  $H$  of a group  $G$  is a subgroup if and only if

$$\forall(a, b \in H) : ab^{-1} \in H$$

**Proof:** It is clear that if  $H$  is a subgroup, then the stated condition holds indeed, for  $a, b \in H$ , then the inverse of  $b$  must also be in  $H$  and  $H$  is closed under the operation of  $G$  conversely, assume the stated condition holds, we have to check that it is closed under the operation of  $G$ . the induced operation on  $H$  is associative and it admits an identity element and inverses. Since  $H$  is non-empty we can find an element  $h \in H$ . choosing  $a = b = h$  we see that

$$e_G = hh^{-1} = ab^{-1} \in H;$$

thus  $H$  contains the identity. Given any  $h \in H$  choosing  $a = e_G$  and  $b = h$  shows that

$$h^{-1} = e_G h^{-1} = ab^{-1} \in H$$

, thus  $H$  contains the inverse of any of its elements. Given any  $h_1, h_2 \in H$ , choose  $a = h_1, b = h_2^{-1}$ ; the stated condition says that

$$h_1 h_2 = h_1 ((h_2)^{-1})^{-1} = ab^{-1} \in H$$

, proving that  $H$  is closed under the operation. Finally, the fact that the operation is associative in  $G$  implies immediately that the induced operation is associative in  $H$ , concluding the proof that  $H$  with the induced operation is a group.

**Lemma 3.3:** If  $\{H_\alpha\}_{\alpha \in A}$  is any family of subgroups of a group  $G$ , then

$$H = \bigcap_{\alpha \in A} H_\alpha$$

is a subgroup of  $G$ . **Proof:** This follows from Proposition 3.2:  $H$  is non-empty because  $e \in H_\alpha$  for all  $\alpha$ , so  $e \in H$  and

$$a, b \in H \implies (\forall \alpha \in A) : a, b \in H_\alpha \implies (\forall \alpha \in A) : ab^{-1} \in H_\alpha \implies ab^{-1} \in H$$

proving that  $H$  is a subgroup of  $G$

**Lemma 3.4:** Let  $\varphi : G \rightarrow G'$  be a group homomorphism, and let  $H'$  be a subgroup of  $G'$ . Then  $\varphi^{-1}(H')$  is a subgroup of  $G$ . **Proof:** Recall that  $\varphi^{-1}(H') = \{g \in G \mid \varphi(g) \in H'\}$ . Since  $\varphi(e_G) = e_{G'} \in H'$ , this set is non-empty. If  $a, b \in \varphi^{-1}(H')$ , then  $\varphi(a)$  and  $\varphi(b)$  are in  $H'$  and hence

$$\varphi(ab^{-1}) = \varphi(a)\varphi(b)^{-1} \in H'$$

. Therefore  $ab^{-1} \in \varphi^{-1}(H')$ . This implies that  $\varphi^{-1}(H')$  is a subgroup of  $G$  by Proposition 3.2.

**Examples(Kernel and Image)** Every group homomorphism  $\varphi : G \rightarrow G'$  determines two interesting subgroups:

- the kernel of  $\varphi$ ,  $\ker \varphi \subseteq G$ ; and
- the image of  $\varphi$ ,  $\text{im } \varphi \subseteq G'$ .

**Definition 3.5 (Kernel and Image):** The kernel of  $\varphi : G \rightarrow G'$  is the subset of  $G$  consisting of elements mapping to the identity in  $G'$ :

$$\ker \varphi := \{g \in G \mid \varphi(g) = e_{G'}\} = \varphi^{-1}(\{e_{G'}\})$$

Since  $\{e_{G'}\}$  is a subgroup of  $G'$ , Lemma 3.4 shows that the kernel is indeed a subgroup of  $G$ . Explicitly, note that  $\ker \varphi$  is a non-empty, since  $e_G \in \ker \varphi$ , and if  $a, b \in \ker \varphi$ , then

$$\varphi(ab^{-1}) = \varphi(a)\varphi(b)^{-1} = e_{G'}(e_{G'})^{-1} = e_{G'}$$

Proving that  $ab^{-1} \in \ker \varphi$ . This proves that  $\ker \varphi$  is a subgroup of  $G$ , by Proposition 3.2. As an exercise verify that  $\text{im } \varphi$  is a subgroup of  $G'$ . check also that the image of any subgroup of  $G$  is a subgroup of  $G'$ .

**Subgroup generated by a subset** if  $A \subseteq G$  then is any subset, we have a unique group homomorphism

$$\varphi_A : \mathbb{F}(A) \rightarrow G$$

. Extending this inclusion. The image of this homomorphism is a subgroup of  $G$ . A subgroup generated by  $A$  in  $G$ , often denoted  $\langle A \rangle$ . The subgroup  $\langle A \rangle$  consists of all products in  $G$  of the form  $a_1 a_2 a_3 \dots a_n$  where each  $a_i$  is either an element of  $A$ , an inverse of an element of  $A$ , or the identity. alternatively,  $\langle A \rangle$  is described as the intersection of all subgroups of  $G$  containing  $A$ , that is

$$\langle A \rangle = \bigcap_{H \text{ subgroup of } G, A \subseteq H} H$$

Indeed the intersection of on the right -hand side is a subgroup of  $G$  by Lemma 3.3, it contains  $A$  and it is clearly the smallest subgroup satisfying this condition. if  $A = \{g\}$  consists of a single element, then  $\mathbb{F}(A) = \mathbb{Z}$  and  $\varphi_A : \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow A$ . The exponential map  $\epsilon, \langle A \rangle = \langle g \rangle$  is the image of this

$$\langle g \rangle = \text{im}(\epsilon_g) = \{\dots, g^{-2}, g^{-1}, e, g^1, g^2, \dots\}$$

The subgroup  $\langle g \rangle$  is the "cyclic subgroup generated by  $g$ "; indeed,  $\langle g \rangle$  is the cyclic in the sense of Definition 2.9.

**Definition 3.6** A group  $G$  is finitely generated if there exists a finite subset  $A \subseteq G$  such that  $G = \langle A \rangle$ . For example cyclic groups are finitely generated. By definition, a group is finitely if and only if there is a surjective homomorphism

$$\mathbb{F}(\{1, \dots, n\}) \rightarrow G$$

for some  $N$

### Exercise Sheet 2

1. Define a homomorphism  $D_8 \rightarrow S_4$  by labeling vertices of a square like we did for a triangle in the notes. List the 8 permutations in the range of the homomorphism.
2. Describe generators and relations for all dihedral groups  $D_{2n}$  (Hint: let  $x$  be the reflection about the line through the center of a regular  $n$ -gon about ) and let  $y$  be the counterclockwise rotation by  $2\pi/n$ . The group  $D_{2n}$  will be generated by  $x$  and  $y$ , subject to three relations such that these relations determine  $D_{2n}$ , use them to show that any product  $x^i y^j$  equals  $x^i y^j$  for some  $i, j$  with  $0 \leq i \leq 1, 0 \leq j \leq n$ .
3. Verify carefully that "congruence mod  $n$ " is an equivalence relation.
4. Prove that  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  consists of precisely  $n$  elements.
5. Prove that the square of every odd integer is congruent to 1 modulo 8
6. Prove that there are non-zero integers  $a, b, c$  such that  $a^2 + b^2 = 3c^2$
7. By studying the equation  $[a]_4^2 + [b]_4^2 = 3[c]_4^2$  in  $\mathbb{Z}_4$ , show that  $a, b, c$  would all have to be even.
8. Prove that if  $\gcd(m, n) = 1$ , then there exist integers  $a$  and  $b$  such that

$$am + bn = 1 \quad \text{corollary} \quad 1.16$$

9. conversely prove that if  $am + bn = 1$  for some integers  $a$  and  $b$

**Proposition 3.7** Let  $G \subseteq \mathbb{Z}$  be a subgroup. Then  $G = d\mathbb{Z}$  for some  $d \geq 0$ .  
**Proof:** If  $G = \{0\}$ , then  $G = 0\mathbb{Z}$ . If not, note that  $G$  must contain positive integers: indeed, if  $a \in G$  and  $a < 0$ , then  $-a \in G$  and  $-a > 0$ . We can then let  $d$  be the smallest positive integer in  $G$ , and I claim  $G = d\mathbb{Z}$ . The inclusion  $\mathbb{Z} \subseteq G$  is clear as  $G$  is a subgroup. To verify the inclusion  $G \subseteq d\mathbb{Z}$ , let  $m \in G$  and apply 'division with remainder' to write

$$m = dq + r, 0 \leq r < d.$$

Since  $m \in G$  and  $d\mathbb{Z} \subseteq G$  and since  $G$  is a subgroup, we see that  $r = m - dq \in G$ . But  $d$  is the smallest positive integer in  $G$ , and  $r \in G$  is smaller than  $d$ , so  $r$  cannot be positive. This shows  $r = 0$ , that is  $m = qd \in d\mathbb{Z}$ :  $G \subseteq d\mathbb{Z}$  follows. Thus  $G = d\mathbb{Z}$ . The quotient homomorphism  $\Pi_n : \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_n$  allows us to establish the analogous result for finite cyclic groups:

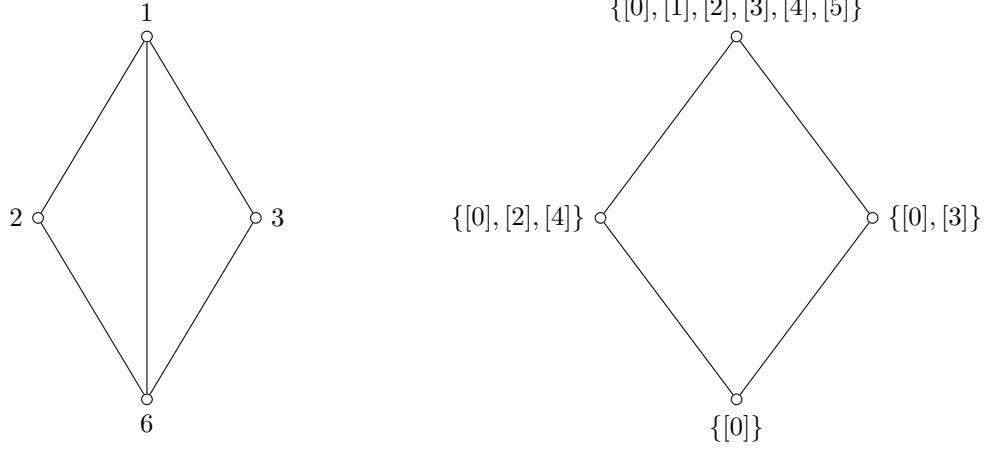
**Proposition 3.8:** Let  $n > 0$  be the quotient map, and let  $G \subseteq \mathbb{Z}_n$  be a subgroup. Then  $G$  is the cyclic subgroup of  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  generated by  $d_n$ , for some divisor  $d$  of  $n$ . **Proof:** Let  $\varpi_n : \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_n$  be the quotient map, and consider  $G' := \varpi_n^{-1}(G)$ . By Lemma 3.4,  $G'$  is a subgroup of  $\mathbb{Z}$ . In addition, by Proposition 3.7,  $G'$  is a cyclic subgroup of  $\mathbb{Z}$  generated by a non-negative integer  $d$ . It follows that

$$G = \Pi_n(G') = \Pi(\langle d \rangle) = \langle [d]_n \rangle$$

; thus  $G$  is indeed a cyclic subgroup of  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  generated by a class  $d_n$ . Furthermore, since  $n \in G'$  (because  $\Pi_n(n) = [n]_n = [0]_n \in G$ ) and  $G' = d\mathbb{Z}$  we see that  $d$  divides  $n$  and claimed. As a consequence of Proposition 6.11, there is a bijection between the set of subgroups of  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  and the set of positive divisors of  $n$ . For example,  $\mathbb{Z}_{12}$  has exactly 6 subgroups, because 12 has 6 positive divisors: 1, 2, 3, 4, 6 and 12. Here is the corresponding list of subgroups:

$$\begin{aligned} \langle [1]_2 \rangle &= \{[0]_{12}, [1]_{12}, [2]_{12}, [3]_{12}, [4]_{12}, [5]_{12}, [6]_{12}, [7]_{12}, [8]_{12}, [9]_{12}, [10]_{12}, [11]_{12}\} \\ \langle [2]_2 \rangle &= \{[0]_{12}, [2]_{12}, [4]_{12}, [6]_{12}, [8]_{12}, [10]_{12}\} \\ \langle [3]_2 \rangle &= \{[0]_{12}, [3]_{12}, [6]_{12}, [9]_{12}\} \\ \langle [4]_2 \rangle &= \{[0]_{12}, [4]_{12}, [8]_{12}\} \\ \langle [6]_2 \rangle &= \{[0]_{12}, [6]_{12}\} \\ \langle [12]_2 \rangle &= \{[0]_{12}\} \end{aligned}$$

Also note that if  $d_1, d_2$  are both divisors of  $n$ , and  $d_1 | d_2$  then  $\langle [d_1]_n \rangle \subseteq \langle [d_2]_n \rangle$ . That is, the correspondence between subgroups of  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  and divisors of  $n$  preserves the natural lattice structure carried by these sets. We can draw these lattices for  $\mathbb{Z}_6$  as follows



## 1 Monomorphisms

Let  $G$  and  $G'$  be groups and let  $\varphi : G \rightarrow G'$  be a group homomorphism.  $\varphi$  is said to be a monomorphism if it is an injective group homomorphism. The following characterizes monomorphisms.

**Proposition 3.9** The following are equivalent

1.  $\varphi$  is a monomorphism
2.  $\ker \varphi = \{e_G\}$
3.  $\varphi : G \rightarrow G'$  is injective (as a set-function)

Proof: (a)  $\implies$  (b): Assume (a) holds, and consider the two parallel composition,

$$\ker \varphi \xrightarrow[e]{i} G \xrightarrow{\varphi} G',$$

where  $i$  is the inclusion and  $e$  is the trivial map. Both  $\varphi \circ i$  and  $\varphi \circ e$  are the trivial maps since  $\varphi$  is a monomorphism, this implies  $i = e$ . But  $i = e$  implies that  $\ker \varphi = \{e_G\}$ , so that (b) holds.

(b)  $\implies$  (c): Assume  $\ker \varphi = \{e_G\}$ . Then

$$\begin{aligned} \varphi(g_1) = \varphi(g_2) &\implies \varphi(g_1)\varphi(g_2)^{-1} = e'_G \implies \varphi(g_1g_2^{-1}) = e'_G \\ &\implies g_1g_2^{-1} \in \ker \varphi \implies g_1g_2^{-1} = e_G \implies g_1 = g_2 \end{aligned}$$

This shows that  $\varphi$  is injective as required. (c)  $\implies$  (a): If  $\varphi$  is injective, then it satisfies the defining property for monomorphism as a set function: that is, for any set  $X$  and any two set-functions  $\alpha', \alpha'' : X \rightarrow G$ ,

$$\varphi \circ \alpha' = \varphi \circ \alpha'' \iff \alpha' = \alpha''$$

This must hold in particular if  $X$  has a group structure and  $\alpha'$  and  $\alpha''$  are group homomorphisms, so  $\varphi$  is a group monomorphism.

## 2 Quotient Groups

**Normal Subgroups: Definition 4.1** A subgroup  $N$  of a group  $G$  is normal if  $\forall g \in G, \forall n \in N, gng^{-1} \in N$ . Note that every subgroup of a commutative group is normal because  $\forall g \in G, gng^{-1} = n \in N$ . However, in general not all subgroups are normal examples may be found already in  $S_3$ . There exist noncommutative group in which every subgroup is normal (one example is the 'quaternionic group'  $Q_8$ ). **4.2:** If  $\varphi : G \rightarrow G'$  is any group homomorphism, then  $\ker \varphi$  is a normal subgroup of  $G$ . **Proof:** As we already know,  $\ker \varphi$  is a subgroup of  $G$ ; to verify it is normal, note that  $\forall g \in G, \forall n \in \ker \varphi$

$$\varphi(gng^{-1}) = \varphi(g)\varphi(n)\varphi(g)^{-1} = \varphi(g)e_{G'}\varphi(g)^{-1} = e_{G'}$$

. Proving that  $gng^{-1} \in \ker \varphi$ . So in short kernel implies normal. Conveniently we can express normality as follows: if  $g \in G$  and  $A \subseteq G$  is any subset, we denote by  $gA, Ag$  respectively, the following subsets of  $G$ :

$$gA := \{h \in G \mid (\exists a \in A) : h = ga\}$$

$$Ag := \{h \in G \mid (\exists a \in A) : h = ag\}$$

Then the normality condition can be expressed by

$$(\forall g \in G) : gNg^{-1} \subseteq N$$

, or in another number of other ways:

$$gNg^{-1} = N \text{ or } gN \subseteq Ng \text{ or } Ng \subseteq gN$$

for all  $g \in G$ . Note that all of these are equivalent conditions. Keep in mind that  $gN = Ng$  does not mean that  $g$  commutes with every element of  $N$ ; it means that if  $n \in N$ , then there are elements  $n', n'' \in N$ , in general different from  $n$ , such that  $gn' = n'g$ . (So that  $gN \subseteq Ng$ ) and  $ng = gn''$  (so that  $Ng \subseteq gN$ ).

## 3 Quotient group

We consider an equivalence relation  $\sim$  on (the set underlying) a group  $G$ , we seek a group  $G/\sim$  and a group homomorphism  $\Pi : G \rightarrow G/\sim$ . It is natural to try to construct the group  $G/\sim$  by defining an operation  $\cdot$  on the set  $G/\sim$ . This construction is constrained by the requirement that the quotient map  $\Pi : G \rightarrow G/\sim$  be a group homomorphism because if  $[a] = \Pi(a), [b] = \Pi(b)$  are elements of  $G/\sim$  (that is, equivalence classes with respect to  $\sim$ ), then the homomorphism condition forces

$$[a] \cdot [b] = \Pi(a) \cdot \Pi(b) = \Pi(ab) = [ab]$$

. However we need to ask ourselves whether the operation is well defined (in the first factor). This leads to a condition on the equivalence relation which we will

discuss. For the operation to be well-defined, it is necessary that if  $[a] = [a']$ , then  $[ab] = [a'b]$  regardless of what  $b$  is ; that is

$$(\forall g \in G) : a \sim a' \implies ag \sim a'g$$

. Similarly for the operation to be well defined in the second factor we need

$$(\forall g \in G) : a \sim a' \implies ga = ga'$$

**Proposition 4.3** With the above notation, the operation  $[a] \cdot [b] := [ab]$  defines a group structure on  $G/\sim$  if and only if  $\forall a, a', g \in G$

$$a \sim a' \implies ga \sim ga' \quad \text{and} \quad ag \sim a'g.$$

Proof:

We have already noted that the stated condition is necessary. To prove it is sufficient, with the stated congruences, assume  $\forall a, a', g \in G$ .

$$a \sim a' \implies ga \sim ga' \quad \text{and} \quad ag \sim a'g$$

Then the operation

$$[a] \cdot [b] := [ab]$$

is well-defined and we have to verify that it defines a group structure on  $G/\sim$ . The associativity of  $\cdot$  is inherited from the associativity of  $G$ :  $\forall a, b, c \in G$

$$\begin{aligned} ([a] \cdot [b]) \cdot [c] &= [ab] \cdot [c] = [(ab)c] = [a(bc)] \\ &= [a] \cdot [bc] \\ &= [a] \cdot ([b] \cdot [c]). \end{aligned}$$

The class  $[e_G]$  is an identity with respect to this operation:  $\forall g \in G$

$$[g] \cdot [e_G] = [ge_G] = [g], \quad [e_G] \cdot [g] = [e_Gg] = [g].$$

The class  $[g^{-1}]$  is the inverse of  $[g]$ :

$$[g^{-1}] \cdot [g] = [g^{-1}g] = [e_G], \quad [g] \cdot [g^{-1}] = [gg^{-1}] = [e_G].$$

Thus  $G/\sim$  is indeed a group.



## Cosets

In Proposition 4.3 we obtained the conditions

$$\begin{aligned} (\forall g \in G) : a \sim b &\implies ga \sim gb, \\ \text{and } (\forall g \in G) : a \sim b &\implies ag \sim bg, \end{aligned} \tag{*}$$

which lead to a complete description of all compatible relations on a group  $G$  (where compatible relations means that the equivalence relation respects the group operation).

In fact, each of these two conditions leads to a description of the relation satisfying it. Note that we have a group structure on  $G/\sim$  only if both are satisfied.

Let's begin with a description of (\*):

### Proposition 4.4:

Let  $\sim$  be an equivalence relation on a group  $G$  satisfying (\*). Then

- the equivalence class of  $e_G$  is a subgroup  $H$  of  $G$ ; and
- $a \sim b \iff a^{-1}b \in H \iff aH = bH$ .

Proof.

Let  $H \subseteq G$  be the equivalence class of the identity;  $H \neq \emptyset$  as  $e_G \in H$ . For  $a, b \in H$ , we have  $e_G \sim b$  and hence  $b^{-1} \sim e_G$  (by (\*)); hence  $ab^{-1} \sim a$  (by (\*)) and hence

$$ab^{-1} \sim a \sim e_G$$

by the transitivity of  $\sim$  and since  $a \in H$ . This shows that  $ab^{-1} \in H$  for all  $a, b \in H$ , showing that  $H$  is a subgroup.

Next, assume  $a, b \in G$  and  $a \sim b$ . Multiplying on the left by  $a^{-1}$ , (\*) implies  $e_G \sim a^{-1}b$ , that is  $a^{-1}b \in H$ . Since  $H$  is closed under the operation this implies  $a^{-1}bH \subseteq H$ , hence  $bH \subseteq aH$ ; as  $\sim$  is symmetric, the same reasoning gives  $aH \subseteq bH$ , and so  $aH = bH$ . Hence we have that

$$a \sim b \implies a^{-1}b \in H \implies aH = bH.$$

Lastly, assume  $aH = bH$ . Then  $a = ae_G \in bH$  and hence  $a^{-1}b \in H$ . By definition of  $H$ , this means  $e_G \sim a^{-1}b$ . Multiplying on the left by  $a$  gives that us  $a \sim b$ , thus completing the proof.

Remark: Proposition 4.4 shows that the equivalence classes of an equivalence relation satisfying (\*) are all of the form

$$aH$$

for a fixed subgroup  $H$ , as  $a$  ranges in  $G$ .

**Definition 4.5:**

The **left-cosets** of a subgroup  $H$  in a group  $G$  are the sets  $aH$ , for  $a \in G$ . The **right-cosets** of  $H$  are the sets  $Ha$ ,  $a \in G$ .

A ‘Converse’ to Proposition 4.4 is true:

**Proposition 4.6:**

If  $H$  is any subgroup of a group  $G$ , the relation  $\sim_L$  defined by

$$\forall(a, b \in G) : a \sim_L b \iff a^{-1}b \in H$$

is an equivalence relation satisfying (\*).

Proof: It is a straightforward exercise to see that  $\sim_L$  is an equivalence relation. To see that the relation satisfies (\*), note that

$$a \sim_L b \implies a^{-1}b \in H \implies a^{-1}(g^{-1}g)b \in H \implies (ga)^{-1}(gb) \in H \implies ga \sim_L gb$$

for all  $g \in G$ . Proposition 4.4 and 4.6 together shows

**Proposition 4.7:**

There is a one-to-one correspondence between subgroups of  $G$  and equivalence relations on  $G$  satisfying (\*); for the relation  $\sim_L$  corresponding to a subgroup  $H$ ,  $G/\sim_L$  may be described as the set of left-cosets  $aH$  of  $H$ .

It is an exercise to produce the proofs and mirror statements giving a description of all equivalence relations satisfying (\*\*). By doing this one should obtain:

**Proposition 4.8:**

There is a one-to-one correspondence between subgroups of  $G$  and equivalence relations on  $G$  satisfying (\*\*); for the relation  $\sim_R$  corresponding to a subgroup  $H$ ,  $G/\sim_R$  may be described as the set of right cosets  $Ha$  of  $H$ .

The relation corresponding to  $H$  defined in this other way is given by

$$a \sim_R b \iff ab^{-1} \in H \iff Ha = Hb.$$

Note: The relations  $\sim_L$  and  $\sim_R$  corresponding to the same subgroup  $H$  may not coincide. That is, left-cosets and right-cosets of a subgroup need not be equal. More generally

$$(\forall h \in H) : hH = Hh = H.$$

Also

$$(\forall a \in G) : a \in aH \cap Ha;$$

So if  $aH = Hb$ , then in fact necessarily  $aH = Ha$ . This holds always if  $G$  is commutative, but it is not true in general. Example 4.9: Let  $G = S_3$ , and let  $H$  be the subgroup consisting of the identity and the  $1 \longleftrightarrow 2$  switch:

$$H = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \right\}.$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} H &= \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \\ &= \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \end{aligned}$$

while

$$\begin{aligned} H \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} &= \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \\ &= \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \end{aligned}$$

This reflects the fact that the two conditions  $(*)$  and  $(**)$  are different.

## Quotient by normal subgroups

Let us recall the main point which is that an arbitrary subgroup  $H$  of  $G$  leads to two partitions of  $G$ , which are

$$G/\sim_L = \{aH \mid a \in G\}, \quad G/\sim_R = \{Ha \mid a \in G\}.$$

The relation  $\sim_L$  satisfies  $(*)$  and  $\sim_R$  satisfies  $(**)$ . As we have seen earlier, these relations, and for that matter the corresponding partitions, are different.

The condition that  $\sim_L$  and  $\sim_R$  coincide translates into a condition on  $H$ : for such special subgroups  $(*)$  and  $(**)$  coincide.

### Proposition 4.10:

The relations  $\sim_L, \sim_R$  corresponding to a subgroup  $H$  coincide if and only if  $H$  is normal.

Proof

Two relations coincide if the corresponding partitions agree.

So  $\sim_L = \sim_R \iff$  left- and right-cosets of  $H$  coincide

$$\iff (\forall g \in G) : gH = Hg,$$

which is one of the equivalent conditions defining the notion of normal subgroup, thus the statement.  $\square$

The importance of the above results is that if  $H$  is normal, then the one equivalence relation  $\sim = \sim_L = \sim_R$  corresponding to  $H$  satisfies both  $(*)$  and  $(**)$  and hence by Proposition 4.3, the quotient

$$G/\sim = \{aH \mid a \in G\} = \{Ha \mid a \in G\}$$

has a natural group structure.

### Definition 4.11

Let  $H$  be a normal subgroup of a group  $G$ . The **quotient group** of  $G$  modulo  $H$ , denoted  $G/H$ , is the group  $G/\sim$  obtained from the relation  $\sim$  defined above. In terms of (left-) cosets, the product in  $G/H$  is defined by

$$(aH)(bH) := (ab)H$$

The identity element  $e_{G/H}$  of the quotient group  $G/H$  is the coset of the identity,  $e_G H = H$ .

By Proposition 4.3 the quotient function

$$\begin{aligned} \pi : G &\longrightarrow G/H \\ g &\longmapsto gH = Hg \end{aligned}$$

is a group homomorphism.

- Include here a theorem.

## Example

Recall we discussed the cyclic groups  $\mathbb{Z}_n$ . Indeed we defined  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  as the set of equivalence classes in  $\mathbb{Z}$  with respect to the congruence relation

$$\forall(a, b \in \mathbb{Z}) : a \equiv b \pmod{n} \iff n \mid (b - a).$$

Now we recognize that  $n \mid (b - a)$  is equivalent to

$$b - a \in n\mathbb{Z}$$

which is the relation  $\sim_L$  corresponding (in abelian notation) to the subgroup  $n\mathbb{Z}$  of  $\mathbb{Z}$ . This subgroup is normal since  $\mathbb{Z}$  is abelian. The “congruence classes mod  $n$ ” are the cosets of the subgroup  $n\mathbb{Z}$  in  $\mathbb{Z}$ ; using abelian notation for cosets, we write

$$[a]_n = a + (n\mathbb{Z}).$$

We see clearly that the operation defined on  $\mathbb{Z}_n$  matches precisely the one defined above for quotient groups.

## Theorem 4.12

Let  $H$  be a normal subgroup of a group  $G$ . Then for every group homomorphism  $\varphi : G \rightarrow G'$  such that  $H \subseteq \ker \varphi$ , there exists a unique group homomorphism  $\tilde{\varphi} : G/H \rightarrow G'$  so that the diagram

$$\begin{array}{ccc} G & \xrightarrow{\varphi} & G' \\ \pi \searrow & & \nearrow \exists! \tilde{\varphi} \\ & G/H & \end{array}$$

commutes.

## Kernel $\iff$ normal

If  $H$  is a normal subgroup, we have now constructed in great detail a group  $G/H$  and a surjective homomorphism

$$\pi : G \rightarrow G/H.$$

**What is the kernel of  $\pi$ ?** The identity of  $G/H$  is the coset  $e_G H$ , which is  $H$  itself. So

$$\ker \pi = \{g \in G \mid gH = H\} = H.$$

Previously, we learnt that every kernel is a normal subgroup and now we have verified that every normal subgroup is in fact a kernel (of some group homomorphism).

## Canonical Decomposition

Injective and surjective maps are so useful because they serve as bricks to build any function between two sets. Every set function may be viewed as the composition of a surjective map, followed by a bijective map, followed by an injective map. We apply this result to groups and group homomorphisms:

### Theorem 5.1

Every group homomorphism  $\varphi : G \longrightarrow G'$  may be decomposed as follows:

$$G \xrightarrow{\text{proj.}} G/\ker \varphi \xrightarrow{\tilde{\varphi}} \text{im } \varphi \xrightarrow{\text{incl.}} G'$$

$\varphi$

(where proj. is a homomorphism and incl. is a homomorphism)

where the isomorphism  $\tilde{\varphi}$  in the middle is the homomorphism induced by  $\varphi$  (as in Theorem 4.12).

Theorem 5.1 makes one aware that to any group homomorphism  $\varphi : G \longrightarrow G'$ , it can immediately be seen that  $G/\ker \varphi$  identifies with a subgroup of  $G'$ .

### Corollary 5.2

Suppose  $\varphi : G \longrightarrow G'$  is a surjective group homomorphism. Then

$$G' \cong G/\ker \varphi.$$

Proof

From Theorem 5.1,  $\text{im } \varphi = G'$  since  $\varphi$  is surjective and so the result holds.

### Example 5.3

The cyclic group  $C_3$  may be viewed as a subgroup of the dihedral group  $D_6$ : the rotations of a triangle give a copy of  $C_3$  inside  $D_6$ . Then  $C_3$  is normal in  $D_6$ , and

$$\frac{D_6}{C_3} \cong C_2;$$

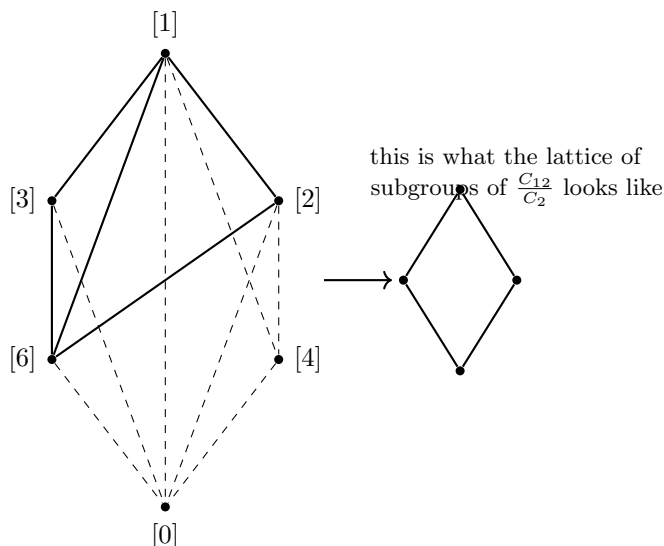
We can check this by hand, noting that there is a surjective grp hom.  $D_6 \longrightarrow C_2$ , whose kernel is  $C_3$ : send an element  $\sigma$  of  $D_6$  to the identity in  $C_2$  if it does not flip the triangle (this is exactly the case when  $\sigma \in C_3$ ), and send the element to the other element in  $C_2$  if it does. Then by Corollary 5.2 we obtain the desired result.

## Subgroups of Quotients

The lattice of subgroups of a quotient  $G/H$  can be described explicitly in terms of the lattice of subgroups of the group  $G$ : keep the part of the lattice of subgroups of  $G$  corresponding to subgroups which contain  $H$ .

### Example 5.4

We demonstrate the effect of this operation on the lattice of subgroups of  $C_{12} \cong \mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z}$  (labeled by generators) after quotienting by  $H = \langle [6] \rangle \cong C_2$ :



The result matches the lattice of subgroups of  $C_6 \cong C_{12}/C_2$ .

Note: As an exercise show that if  $H \subseteq K$  are subgroups of a group  $G$  and  $H$  is normal in  $G$ , then  $H$  is normal in  $K$ .

### Proposition 5.5

Let  $H$  be a normal subgroup of a group  $G$ . Then for every subgroup  $K$  of  $G$  containing  $H$ ,  $K/H$  may be identified with a subgroup of  $G/H$ . The function

$$\alpha : \{\text{subgroups } K \text{ of } G \text{ containing } H\} \longrightarrow \{\text{subgroups of } G/H\}$$

defined by  $\alpha(K) = K/H$  is a bijection preserving inclusions.

#### Proof:

The group  $K/H$  consists of the cosets  $aH \in G/H$  with  $a \in K$ , and in this way it is a subset (and obviously a subgroup) of  $G/H$ . It is also true that if  $H \subseteq K \subseteq L$  then  $\alpha(K) = K/H \subseteq L/H = \alpha(L)$ ; and so  $\alpha$  preserves inclusions.

Next we verify that  $\alpha$  is a bijection and to do this it suffices to write down an inverse function

$$\beta : \{\text{subgroups of } G/H\} \longrightarrow \{\text{subgroups } K \text{ of } G \text{ containing } H\}.$$

Let  $K'$  be a subgroup of  $G/H$ ; define  $\beta(K')$  to be the subset of  $G$ :

$$K := \pi^{-1}(K') = \{a \in G \mid aH \in K'\}.$$

where  $\pi : G \longrightarrow G/H$  is the canonical projection. Then  $K$  is a subgroup of  $G$  and contains  $H$  (since  $H = \pi^{-1}(e)$  and  $e \in K'$ ).

Next we show that  $\alpha$  and  $\beta$  are inverses of each other. Indeed

$$\begin{aligned} \beta(K/H) &= \pi^{-1}(K/H) = \{a \in G \mid \pi(a) \in K/H\} \\ &= \{a \in G \mid aH \in K/H\} \\ &= \{a \in G \mid a \in K\} = K. \end{aligned}$$

So  $(\beta \circ \alpha)(K) = K$ . On the other hand taking  $\beta(K') = K$ ,

$$\alpha(K) = K/H = \pi(K) = \pi(\pi^{-1}(K')) = K'.$$

Thus  $(\alpha \circ \beta)(K') = K'$ .

The correspondence preserves normal subgroups. The following statement is usually known as the **third isomorphism theorem**:

### Proposition 5.6

Let  $H$  be a normal subgroup of  $G$ , and let  $N$  be a subgroup of  $G$  containing  $H$ . Then  $N/H$  is normal in  $G/H$  if and only if  $N$  is normal in  $G$ , and in this case

$$\frac{G/H}{N/H} \cong \frac{G}{N}$$

### Proof

If  $N$  is normal, then consider the projection

$$G \longrightarrow \frac{G}{N} :$$

the subgroup  $H$  is contained in  $N$ , which is the kernel of this homomorphism, so we obtain by Theorem 4.12 an induced homomorphism

|                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| $\begin{aligned} \ker \mu &= \{gH \in G/H \mid \mu(gH) = N\} \\ &= \{gH \in G/H \mid gN = N\} \\ &= \{gH \in G/H \mid g \in N\} = N/H \end{aligned}$ |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|



$$\begin{array}{ccc}
G & \xrightarrow{\pi_N} & G/N \\
\searrow \pi_H & & \nearrow \mu \\
& G/H &
\end{array}$$

The subgroup  $N/H$  of  $G/H$  is the kernel of this homomorphism; therefore it is normal.

Conversely, if  $N/H$  is normal in  $G/H$ , consider the composition

$$G \xrightarrow{\pi} G/H \xrightarrow{\tilde{\pi}} \frac{G/H}{N/H}$$

The kernel of this homomorphism

$$\begin{aligned}
\ker(\tilde{\pi} \circ \pi) &= \{g \in G \mid (\tilde{\pi} \circ \pi)(g) = N/H\} \\
&= \{g \in G \mid \tilde{\pi}(gH) = N/H\} \\
&= \{g \in G \mid gH \in N/H\} \\
&= \{g \in G \mid g \in N\} = N.
\end{aligned}$$

Furthermore, this homomorphism is surjective; hence the stated isomorphism

$$\frac{G/H}{N/H} \cong G/N \quad \text{follows from Corollary 5.2.}$$

### $HK/H$ and $K/(H \cap K)$

In the previous section, we dealt with two ‘nested’ subgroups  $H \subseteq K$  of a group  $G$ . We will now consider the case when two subgroups  $H$  and  $K$  are not nested.

If  $H$  and  $K$  are two subgroups of a group  $G$ , then

$$HK = \{hk \mid h \in H, k \in K\}$$

is a subset. Whenever  $G$  is commutative, then  $HK$  is a subgroup of  $G$ . Another instance where  $HK$  is a subgroup is when one of the subgroups is normal. The following is usually called the second isomorphism theorem.

### Proposition 5.7

Let  $H$  and  $K$  be subgroups of a group  $G$ , and assume that  $H$  is normal in  $G$ . Then

1.  $HK$  is a subgroup of  $G$ , and  $H$  is normal in  $HK$ ;
2.  $H \cap K$  is normal in  $K$ , and

$$\frac{HK}{H} \cong \frac{K}{H \cap K}$$

**Proof:**

To verify that  $HK$  is a subgroup of  $G$  when  $H$  is normal, note that  $HK$  is the union of all cosets  $Hk$ , with  $k \in K$ ; that is,

$$HK = \pi^{-1}(\pi(K)),$$

where  $\pi : G \rightarrow G/H$  is the canonical projection. Since  $\pi(K)$  is a subgroup of  $G/H$ ,  $HK$  is a subgroup. Since  $H$  is normal in  $G$  and  $H$  is a subgroup of  $HK$ , we have  $H$  normal in  $HK$ .

For the second part, consider the homomorphism

$$\varphi : K \rightarrow HK/H$$

sending  $k \in K$  to the coset  $Hk$  (that is, the inclusion  $K \hookrightarrow HK$  followed by the canonical projection to the quotient, i.e.  $K \hookrightarrow HK \rightarrow HK/H$ ).

This is surjective; indeed, every element of  $HK/H$  may be written as a coset

$$Hhk, \quad h \in H, k \in K;$$

but  $Hhk = Hk$  and so  $Hhk = \varphi(k)$  is in the image of  $\varphi$ . By corollary 5.2

$$\frac{HK}{H} \cong \frac{K}{\ker \varphi}$$

What is  $\ker \varphi$ ?

$$\begin{aligned} \ker \varphi &= \{k \in K \mid \varphi(k) = e\} = \{k \in K \mid Hk = H\} \\ &= \{k \in K \mid k \in H\} \\ &= H \cap K. \end{aligned}$$

Thus we have the required results.

**The index and Lagrange's theorem**

The notation  $G/H$  is used to denote the set of left cosets of  $H$ . So  $G/H$  is in general a set, and it is a group when  $H$  is a normal subgroup of  $G$ .

**Definition 5.8**

The index of  $H$  in  $G$ , denoted  $[G : H]$ , is the number of elements  $|G/H|$  of  $G/H$ , when this is finite and  $\infty$  otherwise.

So,  $[G : H]$  (if finite) refers to the number of distinct left-cosets of  $H$  in  $G$ , regardless of whether  $H$  is normal in  $G$ .

### **Lemma 5.9**

Let  $H$  be a subgroup of a group  $G$ . Then  $\forall g \in G$  the functions

$$\begin{aligned} H &\longrightarrow gH, & h &\mapsto gh \\ H &\longrightarrow Hg, & h &\mapsto hg \end{aligned}$$

are bijections.

### **Proof**

Both functions are surjective by definition of coset. Cancellation implies that they are injective.

### **Corollary 5.10 (Lagrange's theorem)**

If  $G$  is a finite group and  $H \subseteq G$  is a subgroup, then  $|G| = [G : H] \cdot |H|$ . In particular,  $|H|$  is a divisor of  $|G|$ .

### **Proof**

Indeed,  $G$  is the disjoint union of  $|G/H|$  distinct cosets  $gH$ , and  $|gH| = |H|$  by Lemma 5.9.

Thus

$$\begin{aligned} |G| &= [G : H] \cdot |gH| \\ |G| &= [G : H] \cdot |H| \end{aligned}$$

### **Example 5.11**

The order  $|g|$  of any element  $g$  of a finite group  $G$  is a divisor of  $|G|$ ; indeed,  $|g|$  equals the order of the subgroup  $\langle g \rangle$  generated by  $g$ .

Note: Thus,  $g^{|G|} = e_G$  for all finite groups  $G$ , for all  $g \in G$ .

### **Example 5.12**

If  $|G|$  is a prime integer  $p$ , then necessarily  $G \cong \mathbb{Z}_p$ .

Indeed, let  $g \in G$  be any non-identity element; then  $\langle g \rangle$  is a subgroup of  $G$ , of order  $> 1$ . By Lagrange's theorem  $|\langle g \rangle| = p = |G|$ ; that is,  $G \cong \langle g \rangle$  is cyclic of order  $p$ , as claimed.

### **Example 5.13 (Fermat's little theorem)**

Let  $p$  be a prime integer, and let  $a$  be any integer. Then  $a^p \equiv a \pmod{p}$ .

Indeed, this is clear if  $a$  is a multiple of  $p$ ; if  $a$  is not a multiple of  $p$ , then the class  $[a]_p$  modulo  $p$  is non-zero, so it is an element of the group  $(\mathbb{Z}_p)^*$ , which has order  $p - 1$ . Thus

$$[a]_p^{p-1} = [1]_p;$$

hence  $[a]_p^p = [a]_p$  as desired.

The index is a well-behaved invariant. It is clearly multiplicative, in the sense that if  $H \subseteq K$  are subgroups of  $G$ , then

$$[G : H] = [G : K] \cdot [K : H],$$

provided that these numbers are finite. In addition, if  $H$  and  $K$  are subgroups of  $G$  and  $H$  is normal, then

$$|HK| = \frac{|H| \cdot |K|}{|H \cap K|}$$

(again if the orders are finite), this follows immediately from isomorphism in proposition 5.

### **Revisit Homomorphisms**

Let  $\varphi : G \rightarrow G$  be a homomorphism of groups. Then  $\varphi$  is said to be an epimorphism if and only if  $\varphi$  is surjective

### **Group Actions**

Let  $G$  be a group and let  $A$  be a set and  $\text{Hom}_{\text{set}}(A, A)$  be the set of functions from  $A$  to  $A$ .

#### **Definition 6.1**

An action of a group  $G$  on a set  $A$  is a set-function

$$\rho : G \times A \longrightarrow A$$

such that  $\rho(e_G, a) = a$  for all  $a \in A$  and  $(\forall g, h \in G), (\forall a \in A)$

$$\rho(gh, a) = \rho(g, \rho(h, a)).$$

Indeed, given a function  $\rho$  satisfying these conditions, we can define

$$\sigma : G \longrightarrow \text{Hom}_{\text{set}}(A, A)$$

by  $\sigma(g)(a) = \rho(g, a)$ .

(This defines  $\sigma(g)$  as a set function  $A \rightarrow A$ , as needed.)

This function preserves the operation, because

$$\begin{aligned}\sigma(gh)(a) &= \rho(gh, a) = \rho(g, \rho(h, a)) = \sigma(g)(\rho(h, a)) = \sigma(g)(\sigma(h)(a)) \\ &= \sigma(g) \circ \sigma(h)(a).\end{aligned}$$

Particularly, this verifies that  $\sigma(g^{-1})$  acts as the inverse of  $\sigma(g)$ ; because ( $\forall a \in A$ ),

$$\begin{aligned}\sigma(g^{-1}) \circ \sigma(g)(a) &= \sigma(g^{-1}g)(a) \\ &= \sigma(e_G)(a) \\ &= \rho(e_G, a) = a.\end{aligned}$$

So we see that the image of  $\sigma$  consists of invertible set-functions;  $\sigma$  is acting as a function

$$\sigma : G \longrightarrow S_A$$

and we have verified above that it is a homomorphism as required.

Conversely, given a homomorphism  $\sigma : G \longrightarrow S_A$ , define  $\rho : G \times A \longrightarrow A$  by  $\rho(g, a) = \sigma(g)(a)$ . Then

$$\begin{aligned}\rho(e_G, a) &= \sigma(e_G)(a) \\ &= \text{id}(a)\end{aligned}$$

where  $\sigma(e_G)$  is the identity permutation.

Next, for all  $g_1, g_2 \in G$  and  $a \in A$ ,

$$\begin{aligned}\rho(g_1g_2, a) &= \sigma(g_1g_2)(a) \\ &= \sigma(g_1) \circ \sigma(g_2)(a) \\ &= \sigma(g_1)(\sigma(g_2)(a)) \\ &= \rho(g_1, \rho(g_2, a)).\end{aligned}$$

Thus we have shown that  $\rho$  is an action of  $G$  on  $A$ .

From what follows we will write  $\rho(g, a)$  as  $g \cdot a$  so that the above will read as follows

|                                                                                                                |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| $\begin{aligned}e_G \cdot a &= a \quad \text{and} \\ (g_1g_2) \cdot a &= g_1 \cdot (g_2 \cdot a)\end{aligned}$ |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

### Note:

If  $G$  acts on  $A$ , then  $e_G \cdot a = a$  for every  $a \in A$ ; the action of a group  $G$  on a set  $A$  is faithful if and only if the identity  $e_G$  is the only element  $g \in G$  such that  $g \cdot a = a$  for all  $a \in A$ , that is, fixing every element of  $A$ .

An action is free if the identity  $e_G$  is the only element fixing any element of  $A$ .

- Include another definition on the next page.

### Example 6.2

- Every group  $G$  acts in a natural way on the underlying set  $G$ . The function  $\rho : G \times G \longrightarrow G$  is simply the group operation:

$$(\forall g, a \in G) : \rho(g, a) = ga.$$

This is referred to as the action by left multiplication of  $G$  on itself.

- There is another natural way to act with  $G$  on itself, by conjugation: define  $\rho : G \times G \longrightarrow G$  by

$$\rho(g, h) = ghg^{-1}.$$

This is indeed an action:  $\forall g, h, k \in G$ ,

$$\rho(g, \rho(h, k)) = g\rho(h, k)g^{-1} = g(hkh^{-1})g^{-1}$$

### Definition

An action of a group  $G$  on a set  $A$  is faithful (or effective) if the corresponding group homomorphism

$$\rho : G \longrightarrow S_A$$

is injective.

### Example 6.3

Consider the set  $G/H$  of left-cosets of any subgroup  $H$  of a group  $G$ . The group  $G$  acts on the set  $G/H$  as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} G \times G/H &\longrightarrow G/H \\ (g, aH) &\longmapsto (ga)H \end{aligned}$$

### **Theorem 6.4 (Cayley's theorem)**

Every group acts faithfully on some set. That is, every group may be realized as a subgroup of a permutation group.

### **Proof**

Indeed, observe that the left multiplication action of  $G$  on itself is faithful.

Note: A set,  $A$ , carrying an action of a group  $G$  on it is referred to as a  $G$ -set.

So far what we discussed are left actions of a group  $G$  on some set  $A$ . One can also talk about right actions where in this case we have a map say

$$\begin{aligned}\rho : A \times G &\longrightarrow A \\ (a, g) &\longmapsto a \cdot g\end{aligned}$$

However note that every right action may be turned into a left action: From now on, we mean left action whenever we say action.

### **Transitive actions**

#### **Definition 6.5**

An action of a group  $G$  on a (nonempty) set  $A$  is transitive if  $\forall a, b \in A, \exists g \in G$  such that  $b = ga$ .

For example, the left multiplication action of a group on itself is transitive.

#### **Definition 6.6**

The orbit of  $a \in A$  under an action of a group  $G$  is the set

$$\mathcal{O}_G(a) := \{ga \mid g \in G\}.$$

#### **Definition 6.7**

Let  $G$  act on a set  $A$ , and let  $a \in A$ . The stabilizer subgroup of  $\underline{a}$  consists of the elements of  $G$  which fix  $\underline{a}$ :

$$\text{Stab}_G(a) := \{g \in G \mid ga = a\}$$

Orbits of an action of a group  $G$  on a set  $A$  form a partition of  $A$ ; and we have an induced, transitive action of  $G$  on each orbit. So in a sense we can understand all actions if we understand transitive actions.

### Proposition 6.8

Let  $G$  be a group and  $X$  be a  $G$ -set. Then for each  $x \in X$ ,

$$|\mathcal{O}_G(x)| = [G : \text{Stab}_G(x)].$$

### Proof

We first need to show that there exists a bijective map between  $\mathcal{O}_G(x)$  and  $G/\text{Stab}_G(x)$ . Let  $\theta : \mathcal{O}_G(x) \rightarrow G/\text{Stab}_G(x)$  be a map defined by  $\theta(g \cdot x) = g \text{Stab}_G(x)$ . Next we will show that  $\theta$  is well defined: let  $g_1 \cdot x = g_2 \cdot x$ , then  $g_2^{-1}g_1 \cdot x = x$ . This means that  $g_2^{-1}g_1 \in \text{Stab}_G(x)$  and this implies that  $g_1 \text{Stab}_G(x) = g_2 \text{Stab}_G(x)$ . So  $\theta$  is well defined.

Next we show that  $\theta$  is injective; let  $\theta(g_1 \cdot x) = \theta(g_2 \cdot x)$ , then  $g_1 \text{Stab}_G(x) = g_2 \text{Stab}_G(x)$  which implies that  $g_2^{-1}g_1 \in \text{Stab}_G(x)$  and so  $g_2^{-1}g_1 \cdot x = x$  and so  $g_1 \cdot x = g_2 \cdot x$ . Thus  $\theta$  is injective. Now  $\theta$  is surjective because for any  $g \text{Stab}_G(x) \in G/\text{Stab}_G(x)$  there exists  $g \cdot x \in \mathcal{O}_G(x)$  such that  $g \text{Stab}_G(x) = \theta(g \cdot x)$ . So we have a bijection of sets and so these sets must have the same cardinality. This is the cardinality of the orbit of  $x$  is equal to the number of left cosets of  $\text{Stab}_G(x)$  in  $G$  which is equal to the index of  $\text{Stab}_G(x)$  in  $G$ .

Assume  $G$  acts on a set  $A$ . Let  $Z$  be the set of fixed points of the action, i.e.

$$Z = \{a \in A \mid (\forall g \in G) : ga = a\}.$$

Note that  $a \in Z$  if and only if  $\text{Stab}_G(a) = G$ . That the orbit of  $\underline{a}$  has length one ( $\mathcal{O}_G(a) = \{a\}$ ).

### Proposition 6.9

Let  $A$  be a finite set, and let  $G$  be a group acting on  $A$ . Then

$$|A| = |Z| + \sum [G : \text{Stab}_G(a)].$$



### **Proof**

The orbits form a partition of  $A$ , and  $Z$  contains orbits all of length one, hence

$$|A| = |Z| + \sum_{a \in S} |\mathcal{O}_G(a)|$$

where  $\mathcal{O}_G(a)$  denotes the orbit of  $a$  which have length  $> 1$ ; but  $|\mathcal{O}_G(a)| = [G : \text{Stab}_G(a)]$  by Proposition 6.8.

### **Center, Centralizer and Conjugacy classes**

Recall the action of  $G$  on itself by conjugation; that is,

$$\rho : G \times G \longrightarrow G \quad \text{with} \quad \rho(g, a) = gag^{-1}.$$

We know that this action induces a certain group homomorphism

$$\sigma : G \longrightarrow S_G$$

from  $G$  to the permutation group on  $G$ . Pertaining to this action we observe the following:

### **Definition 6.10**

The center of  $G$ , denoted  $Z(G)$ , is the subgroup  $\ker \sigma$  of  $G$ .

Concretely, the center of  $G$  is

$$Z(G) = \{g \in G \mid (\forall a \in G) : ga = ag\}$$

Indeed,  $\sigma(g)$  is the identity in  $S_G$  if and only if  $\sigma(g)$  acts as the identity on  $G$ ; that is, if and only if  $gag^{-1} = a$  for all  $a \in G$ ; that is, if and only if  $g$  commutes with all elements of  $G$ . In other words, the center is the set of fixed points in  $G$  under the conjugation action.

Note that the center of a group  $G$  is normal.

A group  $G$  is commutative if and only if  $Z(G) = G$ , that is, if and only if the conjugation action is trivial on  $G$ .

### **Lemma 6.11**

Let  $G$  be a finite group, and assume  $G/Z(G)$  is cyclic. Then  $G$  is commutative (and hence  $G/Z(G)$  is trivial).

### **Proof**

As  $G/Z(G)$  is cyclic, there exists an element  $g \in G$  such that the class  $gZ(G)$  generates  $G/Z(G)$ . Then  $\forall a \in G$ ,

$$aZ(G) = (gZ(G))^r$$

for some  $r \in \mathbb{Z}$ ; that is, there is an element  $z \in Z(G)$  of the center such that

$$a = g^r z$$

(this is because  $a$  and  $g^r$  are in the same equivalence class).

If now  $a, b$  are in  $G$ , then  $aZ(G)$  and  $bZ(G)$  are in  $G/Z(G)$  and so

$$a = g^r z \quad \text{and} \quad b = g^s w$$

for some  $s \in \mathbb{Z}$  and  $w \in Z(G)$ ;

(by the same argument that  $gZ(G)$  generates  $G/Z(G)$ )

but

$$ab = (g^r z)(g^s w) = g^{r+s} zw = (g^s w)(g^r z) = ba$$

(Note that in the above the fact that  $z$  and  $w$  commute with every element of  $G$  was used).

As  $a$  and  $b$  are arbitrary, this shows that  $G$  is commutative.

We now consider the stabilizer of  $a \in G$  under conjugation:

### **Definition 6.12**

The Centralizer (or normalizer)  $Z_G(a)$  of  $a \in G$  is its stabilizer under conjugation.

Thus

$$Z_G(a) = \{g \in G \mid gag^{-1} = a\} = \{g \in G \mid ga = ag\}$$

consists of those elements in  $G$  which commute with  $a$ .

In particular,  $Z(G) \subseteq Z_G(a)$  for all  $a \in G$ ; in fact  $Z(G) = \bigcap_{a \in G} Z_G(a)$ . Obviously,

$$a \in Z(G) \iff Z_G(a) = G.$$

### **Definition 6.13**

The conjugacy class of  $a \in G$  is the orbit  $\mathcal{O}_G(a)$  of  $a$  under the conjugation action. Two elements  $a, b$  of  $G$  are conjugate if they belong to the same conjugacy class.

### **The Class Formula**

#### **Proposition 6.14 (Class formula)**

Let  $G$  be a finite group. Then

$$|G| = |Z(G)| + \sum_{a \in A} [G : Z_G(a)]$$

where  $A \subseteq G$  is a set containing one representative for each conjugacy class in  $G$  containing more than one element.

### **Proof**

The set of fixed points is  $Z(G)$ , and the stabilizer of  $a$  is the centralizer  $Z_G(a)$ ; apply Proposition 6.9.

The class equation is very useful. In applying it, keep in mind that every summand on the right (that is, both  $|Z(G)|$  and each  $[G : Z_G(a)]$ ) is a divisor of  $|G|$ ; this fact alone often suffices to draw conclusions about  $G$ .

### **Example 6.15**

Consider a group  $G$  of order 6; what are the possibilities of its class formula?

If  $G$  is commutative, then the class formula will tell us very little:

$$6 = 6.$$

If  $G$  is not commutative, then its center must be trivial. The other summands, which are the non-trivial conjugacy classes, have sizes greater than 1 and must divide 6; that is, there are no choices:

$$6 = 1 + 2 + 3$$

is the only option.

## The Symmetric Group

Recall that  $S_n$  denotes the group of permutations of the set  $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ . Previously, we denoted elements of  $S_n$  in a straight-forward way for example:

$$\sigma = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 & 5 & 6 & 7 & 8 \\ 8 & 1 & 2 & 7 & 5 & 3 & 4 & 6 \end{pmatrix}$$

is an element in  $S_8$  sending 1 to 8, 2 to 1 etc.

[Note: there is too much information here and the reader can do little with this.](#)

In what follows we will proceed using the idea of group actions. As we all know the group  $S_n$  acts on the set  $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ ; so does every subgroup of  $S_n$ .

Given a permutation  $\sigma \in S_n$ , consider the cyclic group  $\langle \sigma \rangle$  generated by  $\sigma$  and its actions on  $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ . The orbits of this action form a partition of  $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ ; therefore, every  $\sigma \in S_n$  determines a partition of  $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ .

For example, the element  $\sigma \in S_8$  given above splits  $\{1, \dots, 8\}$  into three orbits

$$\{1, 2, 3, 6, 8\} , \{4, 7\} , \{5\}.$$

We see this as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \sigma : 1 &\mapsto 8 \\ \sigma^2 : 1 &\mapsto 6 \\ \sigma^3 : 1 &\mapsto 3 \\ \sigma^4 : 1 &\mapsto 2 \\ \sigma^5 : 1 &\mapsto 1 \end{aligned}$$

and so we obtain the first orbit  $\{1, 2, 3, 6, 8\}$ . We obtain the second in a similar way:

$$\begin{aligned} \sigma : 4 &\mapsto 7 \\ \sigma^2 : 4 &\mapsto 4 \end{aligned}$$

and so we obtain the orbit  $\{4, 7\}$  and then we do same for the last one also.

The action of  $\langle \sigma \rangle$  is transitive on each orbit. This means that one can get from any element of the orbit to any other element and then back to the original one by applying  $\sigma$  enough times.

### Definition 7.1

A (nontrivial) cycle is an element of  $S_n$  with exactly one nontrivial orbit. For distinct  $a_1, \dots, a_r$  in  $\{1, \dots, n\}$ , the notation

$$(a_1 a_2 \dots a_r)$$

denotes a cycle in  $S_n$  with nontrivial orbit  $\{a_1, \dots, a_r\}$ , acting as

$$a_1 \mapsto a_2 \mapsto \dots \mapsto a_r \mapsto a_1.$$

In this case,  $r$  is the length of the cycle. A cycle of length  $r$  is called an  $r$ -cycle.

The identity is considered a cycle of length 1 in a trivial way and is denoted by  $(1)$  (and could just as well be denoted by  $(i)$  for any  $i$ ).

---

Note that  $(a_1 a_2 \dots a_r) = (a_2 \dots a_r a_1)$  according to the notation introduced in Definition 7.1.

Two cycles are disjoint if their nontrivial orbits are. We make the following observation: We state it without proof.

## Lemma 7.2

Disjoint cycles commute.

The following result gives us an alternative notation that we are looking for.

## Lemma 7.3

Every  $\sigma \in S_n$ ,  $\sigma \neq e$ , can be written as a product of disjoint nontrivial cycles, in a unique way up to permutation of the factors.

### Proof

As every  $\sigma \in S_n$  determines a partition of  $\{1, \dots, n\}$  into orbits under the action of  $\langle \sigma \rangle$ , if  $\sigma \neq e$ , then  $\langle \sigma \rangle$  has nontrivial orbits. As  $\sigma$  acts as a cycle on each orbit, it follows that  $\sigma$  may be written as a product of cycles.

We leave the proof of the uniqueness to the exercises.  $\square$

In our example above,

$$\sigma = (1 \ 8 \ 6 \ 3 \ 2)(4 \ 7),$$

and this expression is unique. We could write

$$\begin{aligned} \sigma &= (6 \ 3 \ 2 \ 1 \ 8)(4 \ 7) = (7 \ 4)(2 \ 1 \ 8 \ 6 \ 3) \\ &= (3 \ 2 \ 1 \ 8 \ 6)(7 \ 4) = \dots \end{aligned}$$

and all of these are 'the same' cycle notation for  $\sigma$ .

## Type and conjugacy classes in $S_n$

The cycle notation gives easy access to some important information on a given permutation.

In what follows we will find out that much of this information is encoded into something simpler than the cycle decomposition.

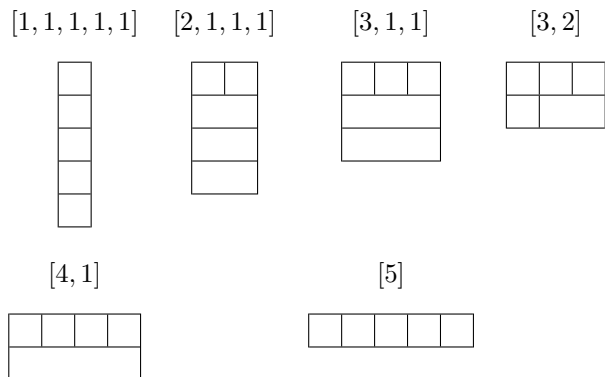
A partition of an integer  $n > 0$  is a nonincreasing sequence of positive integers whose sum is  $n$ . It is easy to enumerate partitions of small values of  $n$ . For example, 5 has 7 distinct partitions

$$\begin{aligned} 5 &= 1 + 1 + 1 + 1 + 1 \\ &= 2 + 1 + 1 + 1 \\ &= 2 + 2 + 1 \\ &= 3 + 1 + 1 \\ &= 3 + 2 \\ &= 4 + 1 \\ &= 5 \end{aligned}$$

The partition  $\lambda_1 \geq \lambda_2 \geq \dots \geq \lambda_r$  may be denoted  $[\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_r]$ ; for example the fourth partition listed above would be denoted  $[3, 1, 1]$ . By means of the Young tableaux we obtain a nicer 'visual'

representation of the above by stacking  $\lambda_1$  boxes on top of  $\lambda_2$  boxes on top of  $\lambda_3$  boxes and so on...

For example, the diagrams corresponding to the 7 partitions listed above are



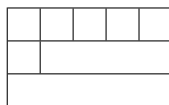
### Definition 7.4

The type of  $\sigma \in S_n$  is a partition of  $n$  given by the sizes of the orbits of the action of  $\langle \sigma \rangle$  on  $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ .

In our running example

$$\sigma = (1 \ 8 \ 6 \ 3 \ 2)(4 \ 7) \in S_8$$

has type  $[5, 2, 1]$ :



The rationale behind the introduction of types is the following observation:

**Lemma 7.5**

Let  $\tau \in S_n$ , and let  $(a_1, \dots, a_r)$  be a cycle. Then

$$\tau(a_1 \dots a_r)\tau^{-1} = (\tau(a_1) \dots \tau(a_r)).$$

**Proof**

This is verified by checking that both sides act in the same way on  $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ . For example, for  $1 \leq i < r$

$$\begin{aligned} (\tau(a_1 \dots a_r)\tau^{-1})(\tau(a_i)) &= \tau(a_1 \dots a_r)a_i \\ &= \tau(a_{i+1}) \end{aligned}$$

as it should be.

Also  $(\tau(a_1) \dots \tau(a_r))(\tau(a_i)) = \tau(a_{i+1})$ . It is an exercise to consider the case when  $i = r$ .  $\square$

By the usual trick of inserting identities  $\tau^{-1}\tau$ , this formula for computing conjugates extends immediately to any product of cycles:

$$\tau(a_1 \dots a_r) \dots (b_1 \dots b_s)\tau^{-1} = (\tau(a_1) \dots \tau(a_r)) \dots (\tau(b_1) \dots \tau(b_s)).$$

This holds whether the cycles are disjoint or not. However, since  $\tau$  is a bijection, disjoint cycles remain disjoint after conjugation.

—  
This is captured in the following observation:

**Proposition 7.6**

Two elements of  $S_n$  are conjugate in  $S_n$  if and only if they have the same type.

**Proof**

The 'only if' part of this statement follows from the preceding considerations: conjugating a permutation yields a permutation of the same type. With the 'if' part, suppose

$$\sigma_1 = (a_1 \dots a_r)(b_1 \dots b_s) \dots (c_1 \dots c_t)$$

and

$$\sigma_2 = (a'_1 \dots a'_r)(b'_1 \dots b'_s) \dots (c'_1 \dots c'_t)$$

are two permutations with the same type, written in cycle notation, with  $r \geq s \geq \dots \geq t$  (so that the type is  $[r, s, \dots, t]$ ). Let  $\tau$  be any permutation such that  $a'_i = \tau(a_i)$ ,  $b'_j = \tau(b_j)$ ,  $\dots$ ,  $c'_k = \tau(c_k)$  for all  $i, j, \dots, k$ .

The Lemma 7.5 implies  $\sigma_2 = \tau\sigma_1\tau^{-1}$ , so  $\sigma_1$  and  $\sigma_2$  are conjugate, as needed.

—

## Example

In  $S_8$ ,

$$(1 \ 8 \ 6 \ 3 \ 2)(4 \ 7) \quad \text{and} \quad (1 \ 5 \ 4 \ 6 \ 8)(3 \ 7)$$

must be conjugate, since they have the same type. The proof of Proposition 7.6 tells us that

$$\tau(1 \ 8 \ 6 \ 3 \ 2)(4 \ 7)\tau^{-1} = (1 \ 5 \ 4 \ 6 \ 8)(3 \ 7)$$

for

$$\tau = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 & 5 & 6 & 7 & 8 \\ 1 & 8 & 6 & 3 & 2 & 4 & 7 & 5 \end{pmatrix}.$$

In summary, the type tells us everything about conjugation in  $S_n$ .

## Corollary 7.8

The number of conjugacy classes in  $S_n$  equals the number of partitions of  $n$ .

—  
For example, there are 7 conjugacy classes in  $S_5$  indexed by the diagrams drawn above.

It is also straightforward to compute the number of elements in each conjugacy class, in terms of the type.

For example, in order to count the number of permutations of type  $[2, 2, 1]$  in  $S_5$ , whose corresponding Young diagram is

|       |       |
|-------|-------|
| $a_1$ | $a_2$ |
| $a_3$ | $a_4$ |
| $a_5$ |       |

Note that there are 5 possible values that  $a_1$  can assume if we are to choose from  $1, \dots, 5$ . Then  $a_2$  has 4 possibilities,  $a_3$  has 3 possibilities and  $a_4$  has 2 possible choices and lastly  $a_5$  has only 1 possible choice.

—  
Now in cycle notation we get

$$(a_1 \ a_2)(a_3 \ a_4)$$

and noting that switching  $a_1 \longleftrightarrow a_2$  and  $(a_3 \longleftrightarrow a_4)$ , as well as switching the two cycles, gives the same permutation, we have

$$\frac{5 \times 4 \times 3 \times 2 \times 1}{2 \times 2 \times 2} = 15$$

permutations of type  $[2, 2, 1]$ .

Performing this computation for all Young diagrams for  $S_5$  gives us the size of each conjugacy class, that is, the class formula for  $S_5$ :

$$120 = 1 + 10 + 15 + 20 + 20 + 30 + 24.$$



## Transpositions, parity, and alternating group

For  $n \geq 1$ , consider the polynomials

$$\Delta_n = \prod_{1 \leq i < j \leq n} (x_i - x_j) \in \mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_n]$$

that is

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta_1 &= 1 \\ \Delta_2 &= x_1 - x_2 \\ \Delta_3 &= (x_1 - x_2)(x_1 - x_3)(x_2 - x_3) \\ \Delta_4 &= (x_1 - x_2)(x_1 - x_3)(x_1 - x_4)(x_2 - x_3)(x_2 - x_4) \\ &\quad (x_3 - x_4), \\ &\vdots \end{aligned}$$

—  
We can act with any  $\sigma \in S_n$  on  $\Delta_n$ , by permuting the indices according to  $\sigma$ :

$$\sigma(\Delta_n) := \prod_{1 \leq i < j \leq n} (x_{\sigma(i)} - x_{\sigma(j)}).$$

For example

$$\begin{aligned} (1 \ 2 \ 3 \ 4)(\Delta_4) &= (x_2 - x_3)(x_2 - x_4)(x_2 - x_1)(x_3 - x_4)(x_3 - x_1)(x_4 - x_1) \\ &= -\Delta_4. \end{aligned}$$

It is in general clear that  $\sigma(\Delta_n)$  is still the product of all binomials  $(x_i - x_j)$ , where the factors are permuted and some factors may change sign in the process. So  $\sigma(\Delta_n) = \pm \Delta_n$  where the factor  $\pm 1$  depends on  $\sigma$ .

### Definition 7.9

The sign of a permutation  $\sigma \in S_n$ , denoted  $(-1)^\sigma$ , is determined by the action of  $\sigma$  on  $\Delta_n$ :

$$\sigma(\Delta_n) = (-1)^\sigma \Delta_n.$$

We say that a permutation is even if its sign is +1 and odd if its sign is -1.

—  
Note that  $\forall \sigma, \tau \in S_n$  we have

$$(\tau\sigma)(\Delta_n) = \tau(\sigma(\Delta_n));$$

it follows that  $(-1)^{\tau\sigma} = (-1)^\sigma (-1)^\tau$ .

Viewing  $\{-1, +1\}$  as a group under multiplication, we see that the 'sign' function

$$\varepsilon : S_n \longrightarrow \{+1, -1\}, \quad \varepsilon(\sigma) := (-1)^\sigma$$

is a homomorphism.

In what follows we give a different viewpoint on the sign function. A transposition is a cycle of length 2.

Every permutation is a product of transpositions:

### Lemma 7.10

Transpositions generate  $S_n$ .

#### Proof

Indeed, by Lemma 7.3 it is enough to show that every cycle is a product of transpositions, and indeed

$$(a_1 \dots a_r) = (a_1 a_r)(a_1 a_{r-1}) \dots (a_1 a_2)$$

which may be checked by applying both sides to every element of  $\{1, \dots, n\}$ .  $\square$

### Lemma 7.11

Let  $\sigma = \tau_1 \dots \tau_k$  be a product of transpositions. Then  $\sigma$  is even, respectively, odd depending on whether  $k$  is even, respectively, odd.

#### Proof

This follows immediately from the facts that  $\varepsilon$  is a homomorphism and the sign of a transposition is  $-1$ : indeed,  $(i j)$  acts on  $\Delta_n$  by permuting its factors and changing the sign of an odd number of factors (for  $i < j$ , the factor  $(x_i - x_j)$  and the pairs of factors  $(x_i - x_k)$ ,  $(x_k - x_j)$  for all  $i < k < j$ ).

### Definition 7.12

The alternating group on  $\{1, \dots, n\}$ , denoted  $A_n$ , consists of all even permutations  $\sigma \in S_n$ . The alternating group is a normal subgroup of  $S_n$ , and

$$[S_n : A_n] = 2$$

for  $n \geq 2$ ; indeed,  $A_n = \ker \varepsilon$ , and  $\varepsilon$  is surjective for  $n \geq 2$ .

It is very straightforward to tell whether a permutation  $\sigma$  belongs to  $A_n$  in terms of the type of  $\sigma$ . Indeed a cycle is even respectively, odd, if it has odd respectively, even length.

### Lemma 7.13

The alternating group  $A_n$  is generated by 3-cycles.

**Proof**

Since every even permutation is a product of an even number of 2-cycles, it suffices to show that every product of two 2-cycles may be written as a product of 3-cycles. Therefore consider a product

$$(a \ b)(c \ d)$$

with  $a \neq b$ ,  $c \neq d$ . If  $(a \ b) = (c \ d)$ , then this product  $\underline{(a \ b)(c \ d)}$  is the identity, and there is nothing to prove.

If  $\{a, b\}$ ,  $\{c, d\}$  have exactly one element in common, then we may assume  $c = a$  and observe

$$(a \ b)(a \ d) = (a \ b \ d).$$

If  $\{a, b\}$ ,  $\{c, d\}$  are disjoint, then

$$\begin{aligned} (a \ b)(c \ d) &= (a \ b)(a \ c)(a \ c)(c \ d) \\ &= (a \ c \ b)(c \ d \ a) \end{aligned}$$

and we are done. □